

Hidden cost of viral AI image trends explained

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Social media has changed dramatically in the past few years, and India has been right in the middle of that transformation. Unlike old times when it was a place to share your moments of joy, viral image trends have taken over the place. What's more interesting is that such trends spread like wildfire on platforms like Instagram, creating a quiet pressure to participate or a fear of missing out (FOMO). From retro 1980s portraits and Studio Ghibli-style makeovers to turning yourself into a plastic action figure sealed inside a toy box, AI-generated images have become the latest way to join the internet's endless cycle of trends.

If we roll back a few years, then the trend we had was an image filter that gave you dog ears and a wagging tongue on Snapchat. But today AI can reimagine your face, clothes, surroundings and even your identity with a few words. What's more concerning is that the difference is not just technical but also a sign of how quickly consumers have adopted gen AI.

Just to give you some context, here are the numbers after a few days of OpenAI adding image generation to ChatGPT. Within days of OpenAI adding image generation to ChatGPT, over 130 million people worldwide had reportedly used the feature to create over 700 million images. OpenAI's COO has called India its fastest-growing market, while CEO Sam Altman has said demand for the company's AI products has put enormous pressure on its compute infrastructure.

For users, many of these images appear to come at little or no monetary cost. But the term 'FREE' does not necessarily mean 'cost-free', as the price can take several forms. The data we as users hand over, the privacy implications of repeatedly uploading our faces, the psychological pressure of constantly presenting an AI-enhanced version of ourselves and the enormous amounts of computing power, electricity and water required to generate and store these images.

So, while the AI-generated selfies are becoming India's latest social media obsession, a bigger question sits underneath the trend. Who is actually paying for it, and what? Let's try to find out the answer to that.

What data you are handing over

Every one of these viral trends we see today starts the same way. You need to upload a personal photo to an app whose terms you have almost certainly never opened. Then you go ahead and type a prompt to instruct the AI tool to make you look a certain way, and boom, you get your results.

While all this sounds easy, research from Pew Research found that 56 per cent of people skip privacy policies entirely before using an online service, and there is little reason to think

